Unlike in Ahmedabad or even Mohali, I slept well in Mumbai on the eve of the final. On 2 April, we left the hotel early for the stadium and I was surprised not to see a single soul on the way. Security was so tight that fans were not even permitted to stand along the team bus's route. It was difficult to believe that I had not seen a single cricket fan. However, the Wankhede presented a completely different picture. It was already packed, hours before the match was due to start.

As we did our warm-up exercises on the pitch, I could feel the buzz inside the stadium, which was feeling more like an amphitheatre. All round there were excited faces. India were playing the most important match ever on home soil. No team had won the World Cup as hosts, but one good day and we could call ourselves world champions for the rest of our lives.

The final

We managed to get off to a good start in the match thanks to an excellent early spell from Zaheer and some great fielding at point and cover from Yuvraj and Raina. Zaheer reeled off three maidens on the trot, which said it all. Sri Lanka lost Upul Tharanga for two to an excellent catch in the slips by Viru off Zaheer and we had sprinted off the blocks. While Zaheer was bowling very well, Sreesanth was not quite so effective from the other end. Harbhajan and I, fielding at mid off and mid on, kept telling him not to give up, saying that he just needed to land one ball on the spot and he would get us a wicket. He said he was not feeling well and felt like being sick. To his credit, he forced himself to keep going in the oppressive Mumbai heat. Sometimes you have to endure pain to succeed, especially when you are playing the World Cup final.

Sri Lanka fought back well through Kumar Sangakkara and Mahela Jayawardene, two of the finest batsmen in the world. But as was the case throughout the World Cup, Yuvraj made a vital breakthrough to get us back in the match by having Sangakkara caught behind for 48. Jayawardene, however, was still out there and he played one of the truly great World Cup final innings. His century set the match up for Sri Lanka, with 274 the target that faced us.

It was not insurmountable, but it was important for us to forge partnerships in the early overs, because the wicket was expected to become slightly easier as the match progressed. The outfield was dewy